Jawaharlal gained recognition and popularity as an intelligent, principled young leader who was able to mediate between factions with opposing ideologies. He was among the first to urge that Indians demand ‘purna swaraj’ (complete self-rule) and was instrumental in formulating the goal of a secular, democratic nation.



The British saw Nehru as a threat, because of which he spent almost nine years in prison. Often housed in poor conditions, he threw himself into reading and writing, and produced several books that remain popular today.

Making modern India

With the looming departure of the British in 1947, several issues confronted Nehru and the Congress leadership. The most pressing was how to create a united political entity out of hundreds of princely states and British-ruled provinces whose inhabitants had not much in common. Nehru’s response was to envision a pluralistic India, where varied communities were united